

Introduction

Magic in the 20th and 21st centuries has taken many forms. As the authority of mainstream religious organizations has waned in many places, smaller-scale faiths have played a part in the growth of new magical practices and beliefs. The relationship of science and magic continues to fascinate people, and magic has become a subject for sociological, anthropological, and psychological study. As access to information and like-minded individuals online becomes ever simpler, practical magic today can be carried out with ease, personally or collaboratively.

Early 20th-century magic was marked by two developments. The first, which had begun in the late 19th century, was the spread of ceremonial magic across Germany, the UK, and France. This Western magic was at its most esoteric and spiritual, indebted to ancient lore and wedded to elaborate ritual. The goal of practitioners was enlightenment

through understanding a divine unifying principle, but the means were not always orthodox. The most notorious magician, Aleister Crowley, took up depravity and wickedness with orgiastic relish.

The second development was the growing impact of mass media. Even before World War I, Harry “Handcuff” Houdini—easily the 20th century’s most celebrated magical performer—drew immense crowds, the result of blanket press coverage as much as of his own showmanship. Magic in numerous guises became a staple of the cinema and, later, of television, winning huge new audiences. Screen depictions of magic have broadened its appeal to that of mass entertainment, whether in fictional story lines or as virtuoso performances of illusion, humor, or physical endurance.

Modern magic looks both into the distant past and to the future. The rediscovery and celebration of forms of pagan magic has been dubbed Neopaganism.



The world of Narnia see p.262–63



Wiccan pentacle see p.265



Medicine man's hand drum see p.281